The “Dao” of the DAO? Eastern Philosophies in Decentralized Worlds

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Reframing the DAO through the Dao

DAO

Decentralized
Autonomous Orgaization

島

dǎo

Island

道

dào

Dao / The Way

DAO and Daoism: A Literary Flair?

Dao 道 = The Way

“the fundamental natural order of the universe, the spontaneous process that regulates all beings and manifests at all levels, from the smallest human body to the entire cosmos.”

Decentralized Society: Finding Web3’s Soul[1]

E. Glen Weyl,[2] Puja Ohlhaver,[3] Vitalik Buterin[4]

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"The Dao is the hearth and home
of the ten thousand things.
Good souls treasure it,
lost souls find shelter in it."
— Laozi, #62

Reframing the DAO through the Dao

Origin, inclusivity

"The **Dao** is the hearth and home of the ten thousand things.

Good souls treasure it, lost souls find shelter in it."

— Laozi, #62

Resonance, refuge

Image source: Ma Yuan's "Walking on a Mountain Path in Spring" (12th century)

Key Conceptual Pinnings and Daoist Imaginaries

Non-action (*wu wei* 无为) as governance

Let things emerge

DAO as digital island 岛

Low entry, porous boundaries

Taoist notion of *xiao yao* 逍遥 or “Wandering”

Inner freedom, effortless participation

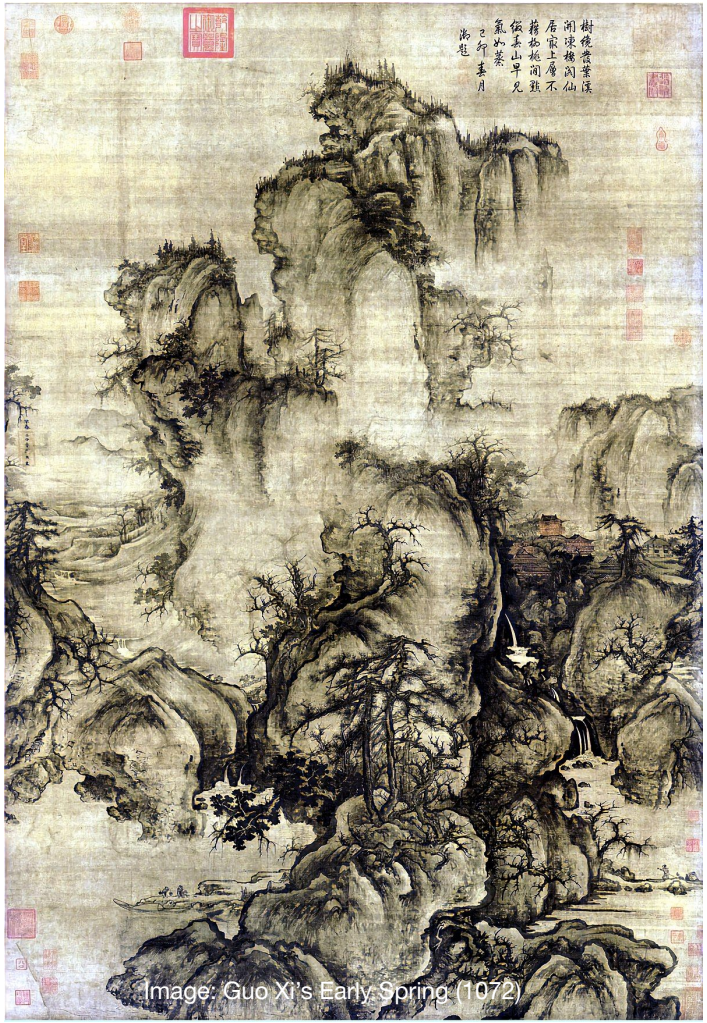
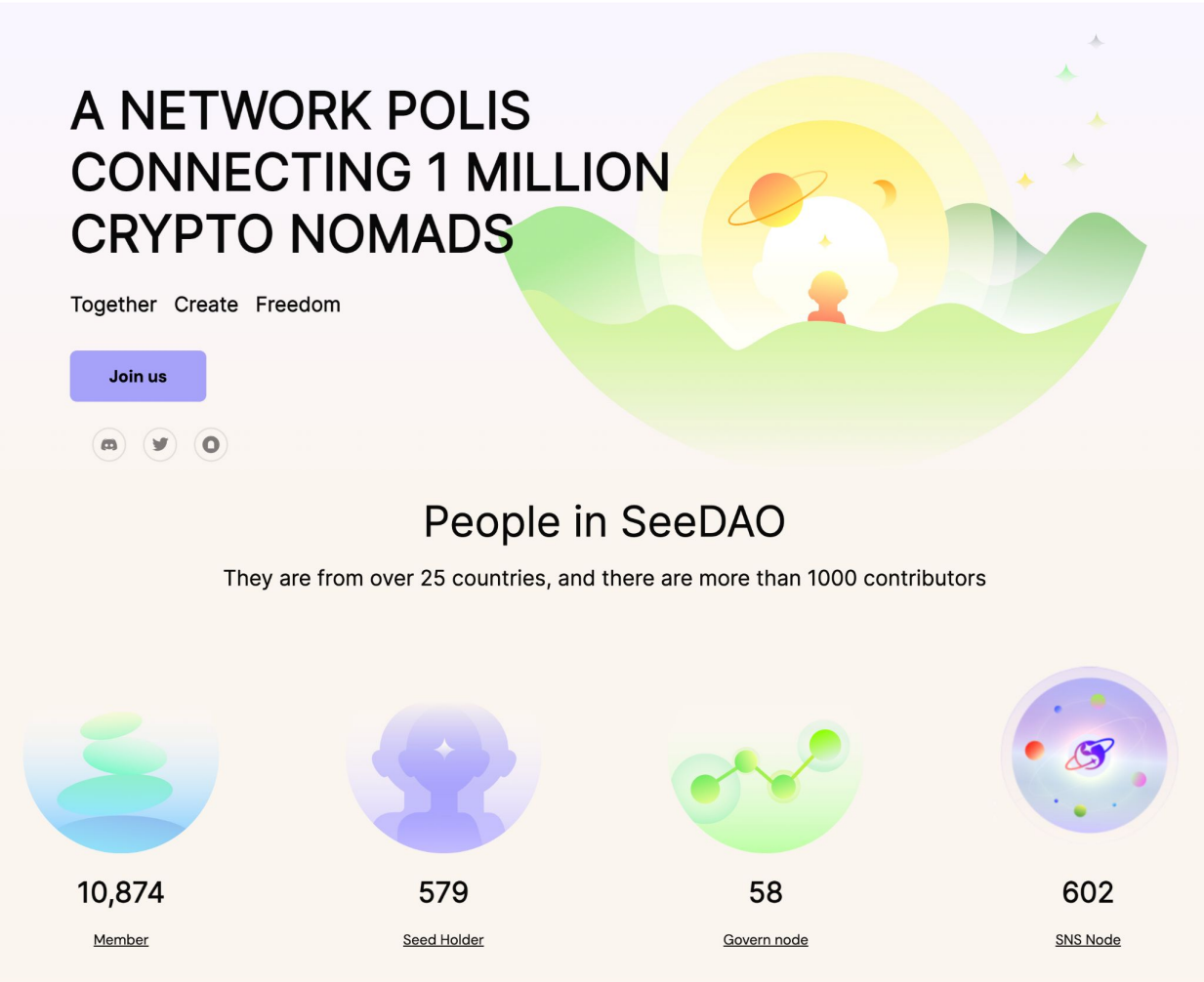


Image: Guo Xi’s Early Spring (1072)

In terms of organizational form, how do Chinese DAOs (diasporic communities) differ from Western DAOs?

On the spiritual level, have Chinese DAOs generated new trends that could offer novel directions for organizational transformation at large?

Case Study: SeeDAO



Eastern vision of autonomy: Freedom as detachment and “wandering freely”

Imaginary: “鲲鹏展翅九万里” – The Great Flight of the Kunpeng, a mythical fish-turned-bird who soars 90,000 li (≈45,000 km), undirected, immense, and undisturbed.

Case Study: SeeDAO

Asset	Core purpose in the "digital city-state"	Transferable?
WANG reputation points	Records each member's historical contributions; gates governance weight and free minting of Seed NFTs	**No** – cannot be transferred or sold
Seed NFT	Symbol of "core citizen" status; required for high-level governance and receives priority benefits	**Yes** – may be traded after minting; selling it forfeits the rights it carries
SeeDAO SBT SeeDAO Name Service (SNS) ID	Soul-bound badges describing roles, skills, work history and other identity facets; enrich the on-chain profile	**No** – deliberately non-transferable
$SEE utility token	Future base currency for all economic activity inside SeeDAO; also used for taxation/burn mechanisms	**Yes** – freely transferable once launched

Case Study: SeeDAO

Who can join?	Anyone can enter as an *Explorer* by creating a SeeDAO Name (SNS) and Discord account. From there you earn non-transferable **WANG** reputation through documented contributions. Once your WANG passes a threshold you may *mint* a **Seed NFT**, becoming a core citizen.
Who can propose?	• *Work-stream & project proposals* – any contributor with sufficient WANG in that domain. • *City-wide ("Node Consensus") proposals* – limited to holders of a **Seed NFT**.
Who can vote?	• Day-to-day team votes weight each wallet's **current WANG** (reputation decays quarterly). • Node-Consensus votes require holding a *Seed NFT*; the voting power of each Seed comes from the owner's **effective WANG** for that quarter.

SeeDAO Digital Nomadism

SeeDAO + Rural Construction DAO

SeeDAO Evolution

Capitalization

Tokenization, technical and financial rationality; external exclusion

→

Socialization

Emergent, unplanned, multifaceted activities; “Wu wei” non-governance as governance

→

Spiritualization

Search for “xiao yao”; digital polis with nomadic form: a unified digital commons that is both cloud-based and place-based
Lightweight, cultural, nomadic sovereignty through shared rituals, memories and good lives

Interview Questions

- **Onboarding.** What draws people into these communities—philosophical alignment, emotional resonance, or opportunistic incentives?
- **Philosophy.** How are Eastern concepts like 道 (Dao), 无为 (non-action), 仁 (benevolence), and 小国寡民 (small country small population) reflected in everyday governance and coordination practices?
- **Rationalities in tension.** What tensions emerge between value-driven participation and instrumental motivations?
- **Endurance and choice.** How do contributors experience burnout, persistence, or departure—what sustains them in the long term?
- **Long view.** Do founders see themselves building an alternative civilizational imaginary, and how is this received or transformed by their communities?